

01

SĀṂKHYA DUALISM, PRAMĀṆAS AND COGNITION

CONTEXT + EXACT CORE

Sāṁkhya accepts perception, inference and reliable testimony as pramāṇas, using inference to establish supersensible Prakṛti and Puruṣa.

MECHANISM / ARGUMENT

The internal organ takes the form of an object and appears conscious when Puruṣa's awareness is reflected in it.

CONSEQUENCE / CONTRAST

Experience is possible without making matter conscious or consciousness an agent, but the relation between the two principles becomes the system's central difficulty.

UPSC TRAP / ANSWER USE

Do not identify Puruṣa with mind, ego or buddhi, because all three psychological functions belong to evolved Prakṛti.

ANSWER LINE: The system's epistemology supports its dualism: cognition belongs to the material internal organ, while consciousness belongs to the witnessing Puruṣa.

02

PRAKṚTI, THE THREE GUṆAS AND THEIR PROOFS

CONTEXT + EXACT CORE

□ Prakṛti (prakṛiti) is the unmanifest, unconscious, primordial material principle from which the entire objective and psycho-physical world evolves. □ It is also called pradhāna (chief principle) because it is the primary material basis of all empirical manifestation. □ It is called avyakta (unmanifest) because in its primordial condition it is not yet differentiated into manifest tattvas. □ It is not a created entity; it is the ultimate material cause of the world within Sāṁkhya's dualist ontology. □□ In exam language, Prakṛti is not merely "matter" in the modern physicalist sense; it includes the roots of intellect, ego, mind, senses, subtle elements and gross elements.

MECHANISM / ARGUMENT

□ Pradhāna emphasizes that Prakṛti is the chief material principle. □ Avyakta emphasizes that it is unmanifest prior to differentiated evolution. □□ An exam-safe definition: Prakṛti is the avyakta pradhāna, the unmanifest chief material principle constituted by the three guṇas.

CONSEQUENCE / CONTRAST

The standard cluster of arguments is central to UPSC. □ Empirical things are many, finite, delimited and measurable. □ What is finite and determinate points beyond itself to a more fundamental source from which such determinate forms arise. □ The manifold world therefore requires a common antecedent material ground. □□ The force of the argument is not merely "every effect has a cause," but "the limited and differentiated presuppose a subtler ground from which limitation and differentiation emerge." □ Effects display an underlying order and common pattern. □ Diverse products nevertheless reveal continuity of constitution and dependence. □ Such systematic coherence suggests a common material basis. □□ This is an argument from coordinated diversity: if effects hang together, they are likely rooted in one underlying matrix. □ The empirical order is not inert chaos; it is a field of production, activity and transformation. □ Productive activity presupposes a causal potency capable of issuing in determinate effects. □ Therefore there must be an underlying productive principle possessing the capacity for manifestation. □□ Sāṁkhya here reasons from the fact of becoming to an abiding source of becoming. □ Cause and effect are distinguishable stages: the unmanifest source and the manifest product are not identical in appearance. □ If effects are manifest, multiple and differentiated, their cause must be a more basic, prior and subtler condition. □ Thus the manifest order implies an unmanifest causal matrix distinct from it as cause from effect. □□ The point is not total disconnection: cause and effect are distinguishable without being unrelated. □ The world is astonishingly diverse, yet this diversity forms one interconnected cosmos. □ A diversified whole points back to an undivided source in which later differentiations are not yet separated. □ Therefore there must be an original unmanifest, undivided root of the whole world-process. □ This is the proof that shows Prakṛti must be ONE. □ UPSC 2019 directly tests this point: if the diversity of the world issues from an undivided source, that source cannot itself be many disconnected material ultimates; it must be singular. □□ This is the strongest anti-pluralist argument at the level of material causation in Sāṁkhya.

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UPSC TRAP / ANSWER USE

□ Before manifestation, the three guṇas exist in equilibrium called sāmāyāsthā. □ In this state Prakṛti is avyakta, unmanifest. □ Manifest evolution begins when this equilibrium is disturbed in the presence of Puruṣa. □□ Disturbance should not be imagined as mechanical collision; Sāṃkhya speaks of functional activation in proximity.

ANSWER LINE: “Puruṣa (the pure conscious witness) is inactive, non-objectifiable and distinct from every product of Prakṛti, while jīva (the empirical embodied self) is Puruṣa apparently identified with intellect, ego and the subtle body.”.

PURUṢA, ITS PLURALITY AND THE WITNESS PRINCIPLE

CONTEXT + EXACT CORE

Reply. □ Sāṃkhya replies that agency belongs to Prakṛti's evolutes; ascribing agency to Puruṣa is precisely the abhimāna that bondage consists in.

MECHANISM / ARGUMENT

Statement. □ Sāṃkhya argues for Puruṣa as a distinct conscious principle because the entire objective complex is unconscious, instrumental and presented to experience.

CONSEQUENCE / CONTRAST

Conclusion. □ This is not a God-proof; it is an inference to Puruṣa as the presiding witness of lived order.

UPSC TRAP / ANSWER USE

Distinction. □□ Plurality does not mean qualitative difference among Puruṣas; each Puruṣa is pure, inactive consciousness, but they are numerically many.

ANSWER LINE: Pure consciousness, being without attribute, part, action or spatial location, admits no principle of individuation; therefore Sāṃkhya proves at most a plurality of cittas (mental streams), not Puruṣas.

THE TWENTY-FIVE TATTVAS AND COSMIC EVOLUTION

CONTEXT + EXACT CORE

□ Rajas supplies activity, energy and operative force to both lines. □ Rājasa ahaṃkāra does not produce a separate set of tattvas. □□ This must be written explicitly because it is repeatedly confused.

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CONSEQUENCE / CONTRAST

□ Buddhi determines, judges, ascertains and discriminates. □ It is the locus where reflected consciousness is most conspicuous in empirical life. □□ In psychology: manas coordinates, ahaṃkāra appropriates, buddhi determines.

UPSC TRAP / ANSWER USE

Do not miss this limiting distinction: □ Ahaṃkāra is the I-maker, the principle of individuation. □ It appropriates functions into...

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ANSWER LINE: □ Mahat and buddhi are the SAME tattva. □ Mahat is the cosmic aspect or name. □ Buddhi is the individual/psychological aspect or name. □ Ahaṁkāra emerges from buddhi/mahat as the principle of individuation or I-sense. □ Therefore the sequence is Prakṛti → mahat/buddhi → ahaṁkāra. □□ This is a classic UPSC trap.

SATKĀRYAVĀDA, PARIṆĀMAVĀDA AND RIVAL CAUSAL THEORIES

CONTEXT + EXACT CORE

Statement. □ Sāṃkhya's satkāryavāda is specifically pariṇāmaavāda: the effect is a real transformation of the cause.

MECHANISM / ARGUMENT

The operative mechanism is that □ Satkāryavāda holds that the effect pre-exists in its material cause. □ Production is...

CONSEQUENCE / CONTRAST

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UPSC TRAP / ANSWER USE

Do not miss this limiting distinction: reply. □□ Sāṃkhya replies that causal capacity in the required determinate sense just is...

ANSWER LINE: □ Satkāryavāda holds that the effect pre-exists in its material cause. □ Production is manifestation, not creation out of sheer non-being. □ Sāṃkhya's specific form of satkāryavāda is pariṇāmaavāda, the doctrine of real transformation.

BONDAGE, DISCRIMINATIVE KNOWLEDGE AND KAIVALYA

CONTEXT + EXACT CORE

□ Bondage in Sāṃkhya is aviveka, non-discrimination between Puruṣa and Prakṛti. □ Buddhi reflects consciousness, and this reflection creates false identification. □ The self then appears as agent, enjoyer, sufferer and knower in the empirical sense. □□ Bondage is not real alteration in Puruṣa but mistaken identification through reflected consciousness.

MECHANISM / ARGUMENT

□ Prakṛti is like a dancer who stops after being seen by Puruṣa. □ Once discriminative knowledge arises, Prakṛti no longer continues its binding display for that Puruṣa. □□ This is the neatest canonical image for liberation through fulfilled disclosure.

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UPSC TRAP / ANSWER USE

□ Puruṣa is like the lame: conscious but inactive. □ Prakṛti is like the blind: active but unconscious. □ Together they explain empirical process. □□ The analogy conveys complementarity without collapsing the two principles into one.

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ANSWER LINE: □ Liberation is *viveka-jñāna*, discriminative knowledge that "I am not *Prakṛti*." □ When the distinction between witness-consciousness and *guṇic* evolutes becomes steady, false identification ends. □ This state is *kaivalya*, the aloneness or isolation of *Puruṣa*. □□ *Kaivalya* is not merger; it is disentanglement.

THE CONTACT PROBLEM AND ŚAṂKHARA'S CRITIQUE

CONTEXT + EXACT CORE

□ Sāṃkhya answers that the relation is *sānnidhya*, mere proximity or presence, not gross physical contact. □ *Puruṣa* does not push or alter *Prakṛti* by action. □ *Prakṛti* becomes active in the mere presence of *Puruṣa*.

MECHANISM / ARGUMENT

□ Unconscious *prakṛti* cannot be the Upaniṣadic cause because the Upaniṣadic source is described as conscious, knowing and *sat-cit* in character. □ The contact problem remains unresolved: inactive *Puruṣa* and unconscious *Prakṛti* cannot intelligibly relate. □ Teleology cannot be explained without consciousness: if *Prakṛti* evolves "for the sake of" *Puruṣa*, purposiveness seems to require intelligence. □ Texts describing the cause as knowing (*tajjñāḥ*-type descriptions) exclude *jaḍa-prakṛti*. □ UPSC 2025 makes this a 20-marker shared with Vedanta.md.

CONSEQUENCE / CONTRAST

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UPSC TRAP / ANSWER USE

□ Śaṃkhara argues that if *Puruṣa* is truly inactive and *Prakṛti* truly unconscious, no intelligible real relation is possible. □ The magnet analogy fails because even a magnet exerts force; if *Puruṣa* were like that, it would not be wholly inactive. □ The crystal analogy may explain appearance, but not the initiation of world-process. □ Therefore Sāṃkhya dualism appears unstable: either it collapses toward monism or it requires a third mediating principle. □ UPSC 2023 directly tests this critique of Sāṃkhya dualism.

ANSWER LINE: "Sāṃkhya (the enumerative dualist school) integrates psychology, cosmology and liberation without a creator God, yet *guṇa*-explanation risks elasticity, *Puruṣa*-plurality lacks a clear individuator, and mere proximity does not fully solve the contact problem."

INTER-SCHOOL DEBATES, OBJECTIONS AND REPLIES

CONTEXT + EXACT CORE

Technically, Inter-School Debates, Objections And Replies is analysed by relating Inter-School Debates to Objections, then testing the relationship through Replies and Priority.

MECHANISM / ARGUMENT

□ How can unconscious *Prakṛti* evolve purposively for *Puruṣa*'s sake? □ Sāṃkhya reply: purposive functioning need not involve conscious planning; the *guṇa*-structure itself yields ordered manifestation in the presence of *Puruṣa*. □□ This reply preserves system-internal sufficiency but remains vulnerable to Vedāntic criticism. □ If *Puruṣa* and *Prakṛti* are radically different, how can misidentification occur? □ Sāṃkhya reply: through proximity, reflection and false attribution rather than real fusion. □□ This is partly explanatory and partly analogical; critics see it as the school's weakest point. □ Could not one consciousness appear as many? □ Sāṃkhya reply: non-simultaneous liberation, individual experience and differentiated embodiment support plurality. □ If effect already exists, production is redundant. □ Sāṃkhya reply: production is manifestation from latent to patent, not pointless repetition.

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CONSEQUENCE / CONTRAST

□□ Priority: Primary ownership rises to 10 of 112 parts and occurs in every year. □ Required doctrinal depth: The restored questions require plurality of Puruṣas, a defence of Prakṛtipariṇāmavāda against Advaita and application of satkāryavāda to the mango-seed example while rejecting rival causation theories. □ Trap / answer consequence: Do not confuse one Prakṛti with one Puruṣa, or say the gross tree pre-exists visibly in the seed; reconstruct latent effect, material continuity and transformation.

UPSC TRAP / ANSWER USE

Do not miss this limiting distinction: rival - exact objection - Sāṃkhya reply - residual force.

ANSWER LINE: “The power of Sāṃkhya (the enumerative dualist school) lies in connecting epistemology, material continuity, empirical consciousness and liberation within one system; its weakness is that the relation required to connect its two absolutes remains under-explained.”.

PRESUPPOSITIONS, COMPARISONS AND GRADED VERDICT

CONTEXT + EXACT CORE

Sāṃkhya vs Advaita on satkāryavāda. □□ Both can be treated as satkāryavādins because both deny sheer creation from non-being; the decisive difference is pariṇāma versus vivarta.

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CONSEQUENCE / CONTRAST

20 marks. □□ Sāṃkhya is a philosophically serious non-theistic system whose causal realism and psychology of reflection are impressive, but whose unconscious teleology and plurality of attributeless Puruṣas remain unresolved pressure points.

UPSC TRAP / ANSWER USE

A web result claiming adoption of a national "Sāṃkhya Paradigm" in mental-health policy was not supported by an official government source and is excluded.

ANSWER LINE: “A high-scoring Sāṃkhya (enumerative dualist school) answer should state the dualist thesis, present the exact proof or evolutionary sequence, confront the contact or teleology objection, and conclude with a qualified verdict rather than a slogan.”.